RESEARCH PAPER

Microsoft Intune Administrative Roles and the Security of Delegated Access

A complete role inventory and governance analysis

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Abstract

Microsoft Intune delegates endpoint administration through nine standard built-in roles, optional Windows 365 Cloud PC roles, and Microsoft Entra roles whose authority can reach into the Intune admin center. This paper catalogs those roles, explains the difference between permissions and their assignment scope, and evaluates the security consequences of broad administrative access. The evidence comes from Microsoft's current role permission reference and supporting guidance, reviewed on October 22, 2026. The principal finding is that a role's label alone is an inadequate measure of risk: a help desk role can have destructive remote actions, a read-only role can expose sensitive recovery material, and an Entra-wide administrator can bypass the narrow scope expected of Intune RBAC. A defensible model uses task-specific roles, group and object scoping, time-limited elevation, approval for high-impact changes, and routine review of effective permissions (Microsoft, 2026b, 2026d, 2026f).

Keywords: Microsoft Intune, role-based access control, Microsoft Entra, endpoint security, least privilege

Introduction

Intune administration is a security boundary because its permissions can change endpoint controls, deploy software and scripts, expose device information, and initiate remote actions. The Microsoft Intune admin center combines service-native Intune RBAC with access originating in Microsoft Entra and Windows 365. A person who can open a blade in the console therefore does not necessarily hold an Intune role. Conversely, a powerful Entra role may confer tenant-wide Intune authority without being constrained by the scope tags intended for delegated Intune administrators (Microsoft, 2026d, 2026f).

This paper answers two questions relevant to an endpoint engineering or SOC hiring panel: What are the complete published role categories, and how should an organization grant them without creating avoidable operational risk? It is a document-based analysis of Microsoft's published permissions, not a measurement of a particular tenant. Feature licensing and effective rights must be checked in the target tenant before an assignment is approved.

How Intune RBAC actually grants authority

An Intune role contains permission categories and actions such as read, create, update, assign, or delete. A role assignment links those rights to an administrator group, scope groups defining which users and devices the administrator may manage, and scope tags affecting which Intune objects are visible. Multiple assignments can extend effective authority. Built-in role definitions are fixed; a custom role allows a narrower set of permissions (Microsoft, 2026c, 2026d, 2026f).

The key architectural distinction is between three layers: Intune RBAC for service-native delegated work, Microsoft Entra roles with cross-service authority, and Windows 365 Cloud PC roles within a related workload. Users, groups, and Conditional Access exposed through the Intune experience are Entra objects. Their presence in the interface does not turn an Entra permission into an Intune role (Microsoft, 2026d).

The nine standard built-in Intune roles

Microsoft's built-in permission reference enumerates exactly nine standard Intune roles. Table 1 summarizes their work and highlights one decision an access reviewer should make before granting each role (Microsoft, 2026b).

Table 1 Standard Intune built-in roles and operational implications

ROLE	PRIMARY RESPONSIBILITY	ACCESS REVIEW NOTE
Application Manager	Manages and assigns mobile and managed apps; reads device and configuration details.	Separate app packaging from broad device actions; managed-app data wipe is included.
Endpoint Privilege Manager	Authors and assigns EPM policies; views reports and acts on elevation requests.	Treat elevation approval as privileged software execution authority.
Endpoint Privilege Reader	Views EPM policies, reports, and elevation requests.	Appropriate for review when EPM modification is unnecessary.
Endpoint Security Manager	Manages security baselines, compliance, ASR, EDR, and related security controls.	Powerful security role; review device actions and EPM rights, not only policy editing.
Help Desk Operator	Supports devices and users, assigns apps or policies, and executes permitted remote tasks.	Published permissions include retire and wipe; scope tightly.
Intune Role Administrator	Creates and manages custom roles and assigns Intune roles to administrators.	Protect as a delegation authority; review changes independently.
Policy and Profile Manager	Manages compliance, configuration, enrollment profiles, identifiers, and policy sets.	Can affect many devices through broad assignments; stage changes.
Read Only Operator	Views inventory, policies, enrollment, apps, and reports.	Some read permissions expose sensitive material, including FileVault keys.
School Administrator	Manages apps, settings, and devices for assigned education groups.	Limit to the appropriate school or group scope and review remote actions.

The table is a role summary rather than a substitute for the per-action matrix. For instance, the published Help Desk Operator list includes wipe and retire, and Read Only Operator includes “Get FileVault key.” The Endpoint Security Manager also has rights extending beyond the short name of the role, including security policy work, some remote tasks, and EPM actions. An approval decision should be based on the full permission list and effective assignment, not the role title (Microsoft, 2026b).

Microsoft Entra roles with Intune access

Microsoft’s Intune RBAC overview lists eleven Entra roles in its access table. Table 2 reproduces their Intune data and audit access at the level Microsoft publishes. “None” means the Entra role does not receive that Intune data category through the table; it can still have authority over its own Entra or compliance workload (Microsoft, 2026d).

Table 2 Microsoft Entra roles in the Intune access table

ENTRA ROLE	INTUNE DATA	AUDIT	INTERPRETATION
Global Administrator	Read/write	Read/write	Tenant-wide administration.
Intune Administrator	Read/write	Read/write	Tenant-wide Intune administration; API name may be Intune Service Administrator.
Conditional Access Administrator	None	None	Controls Entra Conditional Access, an adjacent access decision layer.
Security Administrator	Read generally; full Endpoint Security node	Read	Security administration with broad visibility.
Security Operator	Read	Read	Security operations visibility.
Security Reader	Read	Read	Security review visibility.
Compliance Administrator	None	Read	Compliance workload plus Intune audit visibility.
Compliance Data Administrator	None	Read	Compliance data workload plus Intune audit visibility.
Global Reader	Read	Read	Cross-service observation.
Helpdesk Administrator	Read	Read	Entra helpdesk role; verify effective Intune actions separately.
Reports Reader	None	Read	Intune audit visibility through reporting role.

Microsoft describes the Entra Helpdesk Administrator as equivalent to Intune Help Desk Operator while the same overview table shows read-only Intune data for the Entra role. That apparent mismatch is a reason to test the effective permission for a particular remote action rather than treating the two labels as interchangeable. Intune Administrator and Intune Role Administrator are likewise distinct: the former is an Entra role with broad Intune read/write authority; the latter delegates Intune RBAC roles (Microsoft, 2026d).

Windows 365 and Azure infrastructure roles

A tenant with Windows 365 can expose Cloud PC Administrator and Cloud PC Reader in the Intune admin center. The former manages Cloud PC provisioning, images, network connections, and related resources; the latter views Cloud PC information without changing it. Windows 365 Administrator is a separate Microsoft Entra role for Windows 365 management, not a third standard Intune role (Microsoft, 2026g).

The Windows 365 Network Interface Contributor and Windows 365 Network User roles are Azure resource roles used by the Windows 365 service for network interface creation and virtual network joining. They should be inventoried during a Windows 365 access review, but they are service-side infrastructure roles rather than additions to Intune's nine built-in administrator roles (Microsoft, 2026g).

Security analysis and least privilege design

The role catalog suggests four areas of heightened exposure. First, software deployment and scripting can change code executed on managed devices. Second, policy authorship can weaken safeguards across a large assignment group. Third, remote tasks can be destructive or expose recovery material. Fourth, role administration can expand another administrator's authority. These are analytic risk categories derived from Microsoft's permission matrix; they are not Microsoft-defined role tiers (Microsoft, 2026b).

A practical design starts with the job task and selects the narrowest workable role. A SOC analyst who investigates compliance and policy status may need a custom read role rather than Endpoint Security Manager. An app engineer needs Application Manager scoped to the relevant population. A help desk team may need selected remote actions but not every action supplied by the built-in role. In each case the role, group membership, scope groups, scope tags,

and effective permission report should be reviewed together (Microsoft, 2026c, 2026d, 2026f).

Scope design deserves special attention. Microsoft notes that an Entra Intune Administrator's global access is not limited by Intune RBAC scope tags. Microsoft also documents an opt-in scoped-permissions behavior introduced in 2026: without it, permissions from multiple role assignments sharing a permission category can merge more broadly across tags than administrators expect. Before changing that behavior, Microsoft recommends reviewing the Permissions Assessment Report because enabling the preview changes effective rights (Microsoft, 2026f).

For changes that could affect many endpoints, Multi Admin Approval can require a second administrator to approve protected operations, including role changes. This provides a review point for changes to role permissions, administrator groups, and assignments. Approval is a complement to narrow roles and testing, not a replacement for them (Microsoft, 2026e).

An implementable review procedure

- Inventory Intune built-in and custom roles, Entra role assignments, and Windows 365 roles in the tenant; record the administrative groups that hold each assignment.
- Map each role to a named operational task and inspect every granted action, especially app deployment, scripts, EPM requests, device wipe, recovery keys, and role assignment.
- Review scope groups and scope tags together. Test effective permissions with a representative administrator account, particularly when one person has multiple roles.
- Use a custom role when the built-in role grants unnecessary actions; reserve broad Entra roles for tasks that specifically require them.
- Require independent approval and audit review for high-impact changes; periodically revoke stale membership and validate that scoped teams cannot reach another team's devices or objects.

This procedure is my operational synthesis of Microsoft's role assignment, scoping, custom-role, and Multi Admin Approval guidance. It should be adapted to the tenant's licensing, platform mix, and separation-of-duties policy (Microsoft, 2026a, 2026c, 2026e, 2026f).

Conclusion

The complete published catalog consists of nine standard built-in Intune roles, two additional Cloud PC roles in applicable Windows 365 tenants, and eleven Entra roles in Microsoft's Intune access table. The count alone does not establish safe delegation. Administrators should evaluate the actions inside each role, the users and devices within scope, the visibility of managed objects, and any parallel Entra authority. That approach turns a role list into a testable access-control design suitable for endpoint engineering and security operations (Microsoft, 2026b, 2026d, 2026g).

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